

interview of the week BENAZIR BHUTTO

"MUSHARRAF CAN'T BECOME PRESIDENT"

For seven long years Benazir Bhutto has been dreaming of returning to Pakistan, the country she has served as prime minister twice. As she began finalising the details of her impending return to her homeland, the excitement was laced with uncertainty. Not surprising, since last week another former prime minister, Nawaz Sharif, who too was on a homecoming after eight years, was bundled from one airplane to another and banished to Jeddah in Saudi Arabia. The Pakistan People's Party (PPP) leader spoke to INDIA TODAY Editor PRABHU CHAWLA for Aaj Tak. Excerpts from the interview.

Q. So how do you feel about your impending departure for home?

A. I am very excited. Seven years is a long time and I am wondering what changes have taken place.

Q. What do you expect? A red carpet or the reception that Sharif got?

A. I don't know how I will be received. But I am not in the same boat as him. He has been convicted by the court of law and sentenced for treason and tax evasion. He had traded his imprisonment for a 10-year exile in Saudi Arabia with his family and this involved foreign guarantees. I was given the same offer. But I refused. So unlike Nawaz Sharif, I cannot be put on a plane and sent out.

Q. But the Government will not allow you also to return as there are charges pending against you.

A. The corruption charges against me have not been withdrawn. As far as I am concerned, I am out on bail and should not be arrested. I stayed out so I would not lose my freedom of expression, freedom of speech, freedom of movement and association.

Q. Is there an agreement with General Musharraf that he would be your presidential choice and you will be his prime minister?

A. The discussion or transition to democracy has not been successful so far. I am going back in an uncertain environment.

Q. Is there any deal with him?

A. Of course not. Please do not use this word. It is unfair to my long history of suffering.

Q. I know you will not admit it but you went to Abu Dhabi to meet him.

A. That was a non-meeting.

Q. Non-meeting or no meeting.

A. Neither side has officially admitted to the meeting. But contacts between the regime and PPP have been taking place since 1999.

Q. General Musharraf's popularity is on the wane and he needs a civilian face to stay in power. Are you willing to protect him?

A. Whether he needs someone to protect him or not, only he can answer. But the people of Pakistan need someone to fight for their rights.

Q. You are Benazir Bhutto, who is in exile, facing persecution and whose father was executed. Is it right on your part to compromise with someone who has deposed an elected prime minister?

A. I cannot compromise. I am seeking the restoration of democracy.

Q. Prime ministers rarely survive their full term in Pakistan. You yourself were dismissed twice. Is there something wrong with the DNA of Pakistan which makes military rulers throw out elected rulers?

A. I feel very upset to hear that there is something wrong with the DNA of Pakistan. Unfortunately, the military has impeded the democratic growth of Pakistan, unlike in India where you have a democracy and a peaceful transfer of power. India is also emerging as an economic powerhouse and is a force to reckon with on the world stage.

Q. But we have the same blood. We are only divided by geography.

A. Because of the military, Pakistan has not developed institu-

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"I HAVE NO AGREEMENTS. I AM GOING BACK WITHOUT ANY CONDITION."